

Sowing and Reaping

Galatians 6:6-10

Small Group Bible Study Series

Source: Dr C Norman Sellers, ThD · used by permission

Editor: The Gospel Vault

① TEXT	② DEVOTIONAL	③ COMMENTARY	④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE
Foundation	Personal prep	Teacher preparation	Group meeting
Everyone	All group members	Teacher / Leader	Small group

① BIBLICAL TEXT

NKJV · Galatians 6:6-10

6 *Let him who is taught the word share in all good things with him who teaches.*

7 *Do not be deceived, God is not mocked; for whatever a man sows, that he will also reap.*

8 *For he who sows to his flesh will of the flesh reap corruption, but he who sows to the Spirit will of the Spirit reap everlasting life.*

9 *And let us not grow weary while doing good, for in due season we shall reap if we do not lose heart.*

10 *Therefore, as we have opportunity, let us do good to all, especially to those who are of the household of faith.*

② DEVOTIONAL

Personal preparation · All group members

"Whatever a man sows, that he will also reap."

Sowing and reaping is not a threat — it is a promise, and one Paul says God himself stands behind: "God is not mocked." Whatever you plant, in whatever soil, will eventually come up. The seed doesn't know whether you meant it as a joke, an accident, or a habit; it only knows how to grow into what it is.

That cuts two ways, and both are meant to be lived in view of eternity rather than the next five minutes. Resources spent gratifying the flesh produce nothing that lasts — decay has no crop worth keeping. But resources spent on what the Spirit values, even when the field looks empty for a season, are already growing toward a harvest that outlasts this life entirely.

The hardest part of farming was never the planting — it was the waiting. Paul knew that too, which is why he doesn't just say sow well; he says don't grow weary, don't lose heart, keep going until the season turns. The harvest is certain. The question is only whether you'll still be sowing when it comes.

Reflect

1. Where are you currently investing your time, money, or attention — toward what will decay, or toward what the Spirit will multiply into something lasting?
2. Is there an area of faithful "sowing" where you're tempted to grow weary or lose heart because you haven't yet seen the harvest?
3. Who around you — especially within the household of faith — is a place you have opportunity to "do good" today?

Whatever a man sows, that he will also reap.

③ COMMENTARY

Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings

Proposition: *Because God is never mocked, every believer's use of time, money, and resources — starting with support of those who teach — is seed that will one day yield either decay or everlasting reward, so we must keep sowing to the Spirit without growing weary.*

Introduction

Paul builds this closing section of Galatians around one of the most familiar statements in all of Scripture: "Whatever a man sows, that he will also reap." It is a great motto — the kind of line that belongs on a T-shirt, a guide for life. And it is rooted first of all in agriculture, which is why the whole passage is dressed in sowing-and-reaping language. Noah received this same promise from God right after the flood: "while the earth remains, seedtime and harvest, cold and heat, winter and summer, and day and night shall not cease." It is still true today — even in the Millennium, we are told the reaper will overtake the sower, a much quicker yield to the same unbroken principle. But it is not only true in agriculture; it is true in technology — whatever you put in is what you get out, garbage in, garbage out, computer people know that one. It is true in finance — if you don't invest, you will not reap. Put your money in a mattress or in a can in the backyard and it will not increase, and it may be stolen besides. And it is true in human relationships — if you want friends, Proverbs 18:24 says, show yourself friendly; he who would have friends must show himself friendly, and there is a friend who sticks closer than a brother. That principle — sowing and reaping — is what Paul now applies directly to the church.

I. The Performance of Sowing and Reaping – 6:6

Support the One Who Teaches

"Let him who is taught the word share in all good things with him who teaches."

He starts in verse 6 with the performance of sowing and reaping: "let him who is taught in the word share in all good things with him who teaches." Now, if you think that's not hard for me to say — think about that, forget me, as far as I'm concerned — but what he's saying is that each believer has a responsibility to shoulder the financial support of the pastor-teacher of the church. This would mean those who are spending their time studying the Word, preaching, and teaching the people. That person doesn't have another job; he ought to be supported by the church, and the church is us.

This would seem strange, I think, to these Galatians — first of all, because of the law. You didn't have to pay each Sunday; every Saturday you went to temple, you didn't have to pay, because you were taxed — there was a temple tax that took care of all of this. So why would they think they'd have to do this on top of that? By the way, that tax was called a tithe. Tithing was 22% — want a tithe, go ahead, 22%. What I'm saying is, it was all a part, all built into the tithing system. It would also sound strange because of the Judaizers — these pastor-teachers were teaching the grace gospel, and the Judaizers would say, don't pay them, don't pay them — they were

teaching against giving to the pastor-teachers. And it would sound strange also because of Paul's own example — Paul didn't take any money from anybody while he was working with them; it was his personal decision not to do that. But it was still the believers' responsibility to share in this way.

Now, as I said, I have a reticence even mentioning this — I don't think we need to tell this group that you need to give to the work of the church, but that doesn't mean I shouldn't teach it somewhere along the line, for somebody else down the road who's going to need to hear it stressed. Paul, you know, didn't take any money — but later on, after he ministered at Corinth, he was in Ephesus, and word got to him from Corinth that some people there were saying Paul was not a real apostle. Why would they say that? Well, he wouldn't take any money — "you can't be a real apostle, he didn't take any money, you know what your ministry is worth? Worth nothing, and that's what we pay it." So in 1 Corinthians chapter 9, verses 1-18, Paul defends himself and his policy — he defends his rights as an apostle.

The first thing he says: proofs of his apostleship. "Am I not an apostle? I'm an apostle. Am I not free? Have I not seen Christ Jesus our Lord?" — that was one of the requirements of being an apostle, to have seen the Lord. "If I'm not an apostle to others, yet doubtless I am to you, for you are my seal in the apostleship of the Lord." The second thing — his rights as an apostle: "My defense to you who examine me is this: do we have no right to eat or drink? Do we have no right to take a believing wife along, as the other apostles do, and the brothers of the Lord, even as Peter? Or is it only Barnabas and I who have no right to refrain from working?" He's just laying it out — apostles take it, and is that wrong? No, he has a right to do that.

Then come more proofs of apostolic rights. In warfare: if anybody goes to war, does he take his army at his own expense, or doesn't the man who sent him also pay his expenses — feed him, clothe him? Sure. In agriculture: who plants a vineyard and does not drink of the fruit, or who tends a flock and does not drink of the milk of the flock? The examples are all around. Then, in the Mosaic law concerning physical labor: "do I say these things as a mere man, or does not the law say the same also? For it is written in the law of Moses, you shall not muzzle the ox while it treads out the grain." Is it the concern for oxen that made God say that — did God care about oxen? No, the point is, it's written for our sakes — that he who plows should plow in hope, and he who threshes in hope should be partaker of his hope. If we have sown spiritual things for you, is it a great thing that we reap your material things? If others are partakers of this right over you, are we not even more? He's just saying, I have this right.

Then he goes on, in the Mosaic law concerning spiritual service — those who served in the temple got paid. He gives a little parenthetical statement here: "nevertheless I have not used this right, but I endure all things lest we hinder the gospel of Christ." Then he continues the argument: do you not know that those who minister the holy things in the temple eat the things of the temple, and those who serve at the altar partake of the offerings of the altar? Even so, the Lord has commanded that those who preach the gospel should live from the gospel.

Now, I can imagine someone was getting ready to take up an offering right there — "let's take an offering and give it to Paul, after all, he needs some money." And then Paul gives his personal reasons for not doing that, for not charging: "I have used none of these things, nor have I written these things that it should be done so to me, for it would be better for me to die than that anyone should make my boasting void. For if I preach the gospel, I have nothing to boast of, for necessity is laid upon me — yes, woe is me if I do not preach the gospel. If I do this

willingly, I have a reward; but if against my will, I have been entrusted with a stewardship. What is my reward then? That when I preach the gospel, I may present the gospel of Christ without charge, that I may not abuse my authority in the gospel." First he lays out, I'm an apostle, here are my rights — I have the right to charge. Then he says, I don't want to do that; I want you to know I have the right to receive funds, but I will not exercise it.

Now, those are Paul's personal druthers. He has a personal method for ministering, and that doesn't make it any more spiritual, and it doesn't mean everybody else has to do what Paul did. He says, you have the rights, and I just don't do that. So that's a long way around for just one little verse — but that's the performance of sowing and reaping.

II. The Principles of Sowing and Reaping – 6:7-8

Now the principles of sowing and reaping. He says, "Be not deceived, God is not mocked; for whatever a man sows, that he will also reap." The first thing he says here is a big red flag: "God is not mocked." The word mocking means to turn up your nose and sneer — don't do that with God, he says. God means exactly what he says, and that first line sets up the rest of the verse: whatever a man sows, he reaps. God said so. Now he gives us four things here — I call them the "duh" statements. You know what a duh statement is — who's buried in Grant's tomb? Duh, Grant. Well, these are the same kind of thing — duh statements out of this passage that are obvious but often overlooked.

A. You Have to Put In Before You Can Take Out – We Reap If We Sow

"Most assuredly, I say to you, unless a grain of wheat falls into the ground and dies, it remains alone; but if it dies, it produces much grain." (John 12:24)

The first one is: you have to put in before you can take out. You know that — you have to put something in before you take anything out, in every area of life. So if you're going to reap, you're going to reap only if you sow. Jesus said it in John 12:24: unless a grain of wheat falls into the ground and dies, it remains alone, but if it dies, it produces much grain. What he's saying is, if you have a bag of grain and you put it in a jar on the shelf, what's it going to do up there? It's not going to decrease, but it's also not going to increase. But if you put it in the ground, it dies — and when it dies, it grows, wheat comes up, and you have a lot of wheat on the head. One little thing has bought all this wheat. But you don't have it unless you sow. So we have to sow.

B. What You Put In Is What You Take Out – We Reap What We Sow

"For he who sows to his flesh will of the flesh reap corruption, but he who sows to the Spirit will of the Spirit reap everlasting life." (6:8)

Not only do we have to put in before we take out — what we put in is what we take out. That's a duh statement too, of course, but that's what he's saying: what you put in, we reap what we sow, whatever we put in, that's what we get out. That's true in the physical realm, and it's also true in the spiritual realm.

1. Sowing to the Flesh Reaps Corruption – 6:8a. "For he who sows to the flesh will of the flesh reap corruption." The flesh refers to the old nature, our human desires. Note the word "his" — his flesh, his nature. Sowing to the old nature, then, is using our resources to gratify our flesh,

for the things that satisfy the old sin nature. That behavior reaps corruption and decay and has no lasting value — if we reap things for ourselves, even for our sinful pleasures, that has no lasting value, and we'll reap nothing but decay.

2. Sowing to the Spirit Reaps Everlasting Life – 6:8b. "But he who sows to the Spirit will of the Spirit reap everlasting life." Now, there are some who see this — sowing to the flesh reaps corruption, sowing to the Spirit reaps everlasting life — and conclude that the corruption is hellfire, and so reaping everlasting life would mean you have to sow in order to reap everlasting life, or if you don't, you lose it, or you never had it in the first place. The Bible doesn't teach that. I have four items here that I found in the Grace New Testament Commentary, from the Grace Evangelical Society, on why it can't be true that a person has to work for his eternal life, or that failing to sow to the Spirit means he loses it. First, Paul is writing to believers — he says so in 3:29, "brethren." A believer has eternal life, and how long is eternal? Forever. So he's writing to believers, and believers cannot lose that eternal life — if you don't know that, read the Gospel of John, look at every time he says "believe," and see what happens after that: you believe, you have eternal life; you believe, you have eternal life — we don't believe our way into eternal death. So he's writing to believers, and believers cannot lose eternal life. Second, the parallel in 5:21 refers to missing out on ruling with Christ in the kingdom. Third, 6:8 is comparable to 2 Timothy 2:12, where the issue is ruling with Christ or failing to rule with him. And fourth, reaping everlasting life is clearly not the same thing as receiving everlasting life as a free gift. So all of that says to me that what he's saying here — reaping everlasting life — is equivalent to ruling with Christ in the kingdom, not the initial gift of eternal life itself, which is received the moment a person believes.

C. What You Take Out Will Be More Than You Put In – We Reap More Than We Sow

(Farming illustration, 6:7-8)

Third — see, what you take out will be more than you put in. Again, using that farming illustration, it's obvious that you reap more than you sow. If you say, well, I have this kernel of corn — we used to plant corn, you put two or three grains in the hill, and as they all come up you have to pull one out, that's a big job anyway — you put that in there, and one of them is sufficient to make a stalk, and on that stalk you get two ears, and those ears have all kinds of corn on them. I never counted, but it must be a thousand kernels, times two. So you're going to gain more — you put in one, you get a thousand. So you put in more, or otherwise you might as well eat that one kernel; if you're not going to get any more, you put it in the ground, one more will come up, no point in doing that — just don't do the harvest stuff, just sit there and eat the corn. So you get more — you reap more than you sow.

D. There Will Be a Time Lapse Between Putting In and Taking Out – We Reap Later Than We Sow

(Farming illustration, 6:7-8)

And then finally, the other duh thing — there will be a time lapse between putting in and taking out. You reap later than you sow. The farmer plants, and then he waits, and when the time is right, he gets a harvest. All of that is to say, sowing and reaping are things that God has set in motion, and this is the way it works.

III. The Pledge of Sowing and Reaping – 6:9

A. The Exhortation – 6:9a

"And let us not grow weary while doing good,"

So those are the principles — now there's a pledge in sowing and reaping. The exhortation is in verse 9a: "let us not grow weary in doing good." There may be times when you wonder — I'm working here, doing this for the Lord, and I don't see anything happening. There are things happening you don't know about, probably. But if you say, well, I don't know whether God's in this or not, I don't think so, maybe I'll just quit — well, don't grow weary in well-doing, he says. God is going to bless that work.

B. The Condition – 6:9b

"for in due season we shall reap if we do not lose heart."

Now there's a condition — that's in 9b: "we will reap in due season if we do not lose heart." If we don't stop — keep on doing what the Lord has led you to do, until the Lord leads you to do something else. Just keep plugging at it — do you think I haven't been telling myself this? Yeah. Do it. Keep doing it. "Lord, when do I get to retire?" Well, that will come later, don't worry about that — some Monday mornings it can feel like that, but just keep doing it. That's a big "if" — we must finish the course. In his last epistle, 2 Timothy, looking back over his life, Paul said he had done three things: fought the good fight, finished his course, kept the faith. Is it important to finish your course? Yes. Paul said that sitting there, waiting for somebody to come in and cut his head off, which is where he was — "I look back on my life, I have finished my course." What do you mean, finish the course? No runner gets a prize for quitting in the middle of the race. Oh, they had a marathon — I got halfway, where's my prize? They had a prize; he didn't finish. The Christian life is not a 100-yard dash. It's not a 220 high hurdles. It's a marathon — you don't have to get there first, but you do have to get there. God has put a course out in front of you, and you run that course — whatever that course is — and when you get to the end, you finish your course. Then you're qualified for the prize. What's the prize? Eternal life? No — except in the sense of enjoying that eternal life. The prize is the crown that entitles you to rule and reign with Christ in the kingdom. That's the prize, and that's what you get if you finish the race, if you continue.

IV. The Priority of Sowing and Reaping – 6:10

So we've seen the performance of sowing and reaping, the principles, the pledge — now the priority, verse 10: "Therefore, as we have opportunity, let us do good to all, especially to those who are of the household of faith." See the word "therefore" — therefore tells me this verse is Paul's conclusion to this section. Now, in a conclusion, you don't bring up any new things — you conclude, you summarize what you just said. So Paul is going to tell us what his point is in this passage. This verse will explain what Paul has been trying to get across to us.

A. He Is Teaching about Law and Grace

"But if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the law." (5:18)

One view is that he's teaching about law and grace. I can see that — the entire epistle, the context, would suggest that he's contrasting law and grace. 5:18 says this: if you are led by the Spirit, you are not under the law. That's good — if you're led by the Spirit, you're not under the law. If you're sowing to the Spirit, you're not under the law; if you're sowing to the flesh, you're under the law. And I can see that — it's intriguing. But I don't think that's it. I think the immediate context is ruled by something else.

B. He Is Teaching about the Use of Our Resources

"Therefore, as we have opportunity, let us do good to all, especially to those who are of the household of faith." (6:10)

Here it is — he's teaching about the use of our resources. The immediate context suggests this, and the contrast here is spending money on things that appeal to the flesh, or spending money on things that appeal to the Spirit — capital S. He started with our responsibility to the pastor-teacher — you have a responsibility with the funds the Lord gives you, the resources you have, to that one pastor-teacher. Then, in this verse, he expands that to all men: let us do good to all men, especially those of the household of faith — that is, the believers, the church, the local people. We have the responsibility and the privilege to see that no one in the body is lacking the necessities of life. That's what families do. That's what he's saying here — especially those who are of the family, the household of God.

Now, when I was about two or three years old, my father lost everything in the Great Depression. We left that place with the clothes on our backs. I didn't know all that at the time, but that's what happened, I learned later. We moved from there to Maryland, then over to Delaware, where my father's brother lived — he worked for the railroad, and he thought he could get my father a job there, which he did. We moved in with him. He had two children; there were five of us. Here we are, all moving into that house — somehow we slept, I guess. We don't know how long we stayed there, but we were there a while. I don't think there was any problem about doing that — this is family. Later on, we finally got a house, moved just a few blocks away — we had four bedrooms and two baths — but then, well, I don't know exactly what was going on, but a family moved in with us: my mother's sister and her family, with five kids by that time, so we had six between the two families in one house. That's a lot of kids in one house. We did it — why? Because it's family. That's what families do, and that's what he says — that's what the household of faith is all about. When we have a need in the family, we take care of that need. We make sure we look for it, find out what it is, let each other know where we stand — and then it happens. Whatever we sow, that is what we're going to reap, in our finances especially, as he talks about in this passage.

Conclusion

Whatever we sow, that is what we're going to reap — in our finances, in our service, in every use of our time and resources. God is not mocked, so the field never lies: support those who teach, sow to the Spirit rather than the flesh, keep sowing without losing heart, and let the household of faith be the first place, though never the only place, your good lands.

Lord, thank You.

④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text

Greek Word Study

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.6	κατηχούμενος <i>is taught (catechized)</i>	G2727 <i>katēchoumenos</i> V-PPM/P-NMS (Pres. Ptc. Mid./Pass. Nom. Masc. Sg.)	STR: to sound down into the ears, i.e. to indoctrinate, "catechize," inform, instruct, teach. THAY: to teach orally, to instruct — the source of the English "catechumen." Significance: describes ongoing, structured instruction in "the word," not a single lecture — a settled teacher/learner relationship that Paul says carries a settled financial obligation.
v.6	κοινωνεῖτω <i>let him share</i>	G2841 <i>koinōneitō</i> V-PAM-3S (Pres. Impv. Act. 3rd Sg.)	STR: to share with others, communicate, distribute, be partaker. THAY: to enter into fellowship, become a sharer, join as an associate — used with the dative of the thing shared, including material relief of another's needs (cf. Rom. 12:13). Significance: a present imperative — an ongoing, habitual sharing, not a one-time gift; the same root as "koinonia," fellowship, showing that supporting a teacher is an act of partnership, not a transaction.
v.7	πλανῶσθε <i>be deceived</i>	G4105 <i>planasthe</i> V-PPM/P-2P (Pres. Impv. Mid./Pass. 2nd Pl.)	STR: to (cause to) roam from safety, truth, or virtue; go astray, deceive, err, seduce, wander. THAY: to cause to stray, lead astray; passively, to go astray, wander, be led into error. Significance: the root of English "planet" (a "wandering" star) — Paul pictures a mind that has drifted from a fixed truth: that God's harvest law cannot be outwitted.
v.7	μυκτηρίζεται <i>is mocked</i>	G3456 <i>myktērizetai</i> V-PIM/P-3S (Pres. Ind. Mid./Pass. 3rd Sg.)	STR: to make mouths at, i.e. ridicule. THAY: properly, to turn up the nose or sneer at; to mock, deride — from myktēr, "nose." Significance: a vivid, physical picture of contempt (the "turned-up nose"); this is the only NT occurrence, and Paul's point is blunt — that gesture, aimed at God's harvest principle, will never succeed.

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
v.7-8	σπείρη / σπείρων <i>sows / sowing</i>	G4687 <i>speirē / speirōn</i> V-PAS-3S / V-PAP-NMS (Pres. Subj. Act. 3rd Sg. / Pres. Ptc. Act. Nom. Masc. Sg.)	STR: to scatter, sow, literally or figuratively. THAY: to sow, scatter seed — used literally of planting (as in the Parable of the Sower) and figuratively of moral cause-and-effect, as here, "sowing to the flesh" versus "sowing to the Spirit." Significance: the present tense pictures habitual, ongoing sowing — a direction of life, not a single act.
v.7-9	θερίσει / θερίσομεν <i>will reap / we shall reap</i>	G2325 <i>therisei / therisomen</i> V-FIA-3S / V-FIA-1P (Fut. Ind. Act. 3rd Sg. / 1st Pl.)	STR: from the word for "crop"; to harvest, reap. THAY: to reap, harvest — used both literally (Matt. 6:26) and, proverbially, of receiving back exactly what one has done, for reward or penalty. Significance: the future tense guarantees the outcome; the harvest is not a possibility but a certainty already set in motion by the sowing.
v.8	σαρκί / σάρκα / σαρκός <i>flesh</i>	G4561 <i>sarki / sarka / sarkos</i> N-DFS / N-AFS / N-GFS (Dat./Acc./Gen. Fem. Sg.)	STR: flesh, stripped of the skin — by extension, the body, or (by implication) human nature with its frailties and passions. THAY: ethically, "mere human nature, the earthly side of man apart from divine influence, and therefore prone to sin, opposed to God." Significance: Paul deliberately repeats "his own flesh... of the flesh," underscoring that sowing to the old sin nature can never produce anything that outlasts it.
v.8	φθοράν <i>corruption</i>	G5356 <i>phthoran</i> N-AFS (Acc. Fem. Sg.)	STR: decay, ruin — spontaneous or inflicted, literal or figurative. THAY: corruption, destruction, perishing — the opposite of what lasts; used of what is perishable by nature and, ethically, of moral decay. Significance: paired in direct antithesis with "everlasting life" — the harvest from the flesh simply rots; it has no capacity to endure at all.
v.8	ζωὴν αἰώνιον <i>everlasting life</i>	G166 (cf. G2222) <i>zōēn aiōnion</i> N-AFS + Adj-AFS (Acc. Fem. Sg. + Acc. Fem.)	STR (aiōnios): perpetual, without end — eternal, everlasting. THAY: without beginning and end; that which never ceases. Significance: per FGR/GES (Wilkin, Grace New Testament Commentary), the gift of eternal life itself is received once for all by

Verse	Greek Word / English	Strong's # / Translit. / Form	Definition & Significance
		Sg.)	faith alone (3:29) and cannot be lost; "reaping" everlasting life here parallels 5:21 and 2 Tim. 2:12 — ruling with Christ in the kingdom, not the initial gift of the life itself.
v.9	ἐνκακῶμεν <i>let us grow weary</i>	G1573 <i>enkakōmen</i> V-PAS-1P (Pres. Subj. Act. 1st Pl.)	STR: to be (bad in) weak, i.e. (by implication) to fail (in heart): faint, be weary. THAY: to be utterly spiritless, to lose courage, become faint-hearted, be cowardly. Significance: paired deliberately with ἐκλυόμενοι below — Paul names both the inward loss of courage and the outward physical collapse that follows it.
v.9	καιρῷ ἰδίῳ <i>in due season</i>	G2540 <i>kairō idiō</i> N-DMS + Adj- DMS (Dat. Masc. Sg. + Dat. Masc. Sg.)	STR (kairos): an occasion, set or proper time — opportunity, due season. THAY: the fixed, decisive, opportune moment — distinguished from mere chronological duration (chronos) by emphasizing quality and rightness of timing, not just length. Significance: the harvest comes at God's appointed moment, not the sower's — patience, not calculation, is what verse 9 calls for.
v.9	ἐκλυόμενοι <i>we lose heart</i>	G1590 <i>eklyomenoi</i> V-PPM/P-NMP (Pres. Ptc. Mid./Pass. Nom. Masc. Pl.)	STR: to relax, literally or figuratively; faint. THAY: to be enfeebled through exhaustion, to grow weary; passively, to despond, become faint-hearted. Significance: pictures a runner's muscles giving out — the finish-line language that fits Paul's "finished my course" language elsewhere (2 Tim. 4:7), reinforced by the "we shall reap" that immediately follows.
v.10	οἰκείους <i>household (members)</i>	G3609 <i>oikeious</i> Adj-AMP (Acc. Masc. Pl.)	STR: domestic; as a noun, a relative, adherent — those of one's own household. THAY: belonging to a house or family, domestic, intimate; of God's household, belonging to the theocracy. Significance: the same word family used of the church as God's household in Ephesians 2:19 — Paul's priority isn't exclusion of "all," but the family-level responsibility that comes first, exactly as families care for their own.

Cases: *Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. | Verb Mood: Ind. · Impv. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.*

Study Questions

Part 1 — From the Commentary

Question	Answer
Why does Paul specifically mention supporting "him who teaches" (6:6) right after discussing restoring a fallen brother (6:1-5)?	Sowing and reaping is a general principle Paul is about to state (6:7); financial support of teachers is his first, concrete illustration of it — the believer who is taught sows into the one who teaches and, in season, reaps the fruit of that investment.
Why would supporting a pastor-teacher have seemed strange to the Galatian believers?	Because of the Law (temple taxation/tithing already funded the system), because of the Judaizers (who discouraged support of grace-teaching pastors), and because of Paul's own personal example of not charging for his ministry — three different pressures against it, none of which changed the believers' actual responsibility.
Why does Paul, in 1 Corinthians 9, insist he has the right to be paid even though he chooses not to use it?	To establish that not charging was his personal decision, not a binding rule for every minister — "these are Paul's personal druthers," and no one else's conscience is bound by his choice.
How can sowing to the Spirit "reap everlasting life" (6:8) without contradicting the truth that eternal life is a free gift received by faith alone?	Per the Grace New Testament Commentary (GES): Paul is writing to believers (3:29) who already possess eternal life and cannot lose it; the "reaping" in view parallels 5:21 and 2 Timothy 2:12 — ruling with Christ in the kingdom as a reward for faithfulness, not the gift of life itself.
What is the difference between the priority Paul gives in verse 10 — "to all... especially... the household of faith" — and favoritism?	It is the same principle families live by: caring first for one's own household does not mean caring for no one else; "as we have opportunity" extends the good to all, with a first responsibility, not an exclusive one, toward fellow believers.

Part 2 — Study Questions

1. Paul says supporting those who teach the word is a matter of sowing and reaping, not simply generosity. How does thinking of giving this way change how you approach it?

Leader note: See Commentary I — the performance of sowing and reaping.

2. What is one thing in your life right now — a habit, an investment of time or money — that is clearly "sowing to the flesh," and what would sowing to the Spirit look like in that same area instead?

Leader note: See Commentary II.B — sowing to the flesh reaps corruption; sowing to the Spirit reaps everlasting life.

3. Where have you been tempted to grow weary or lose heart in doing good because you haven't yet seen a harvest?

Leader note: See Commentary III — the pledge of sowing and reaping; "in due season," if we do not lose heart.

4. Paul finished his course. What would it look like for you to "finish well" rather than just finish?

Leader note: See Commentary III.B and the Billy Graham illustration on finishing well, not just finishing.

5. Who within your own household of faith has a need you have the opportunity to meet right now?

Leader note: See Commentary IV.B — the household-of-faith priority and the family illustration.

Part 3 — Passage Summary

Verse(s)	Theme	Key Truth
6:6	The Performance	Believers who are taught the word owe ongoing, shared support to those who teach it — Paul's own right, though he waived it personally.
6:7-8	The Principles	God is not mocked: you reap only if you sow, you reap what you sow, more than you sow, and later than you sow — sowing to the flesh reaps decay, sowing to the Spirit reaps a lasting reward.
6:9	The Pledge	Doing good is guaranteed a harvest in due season, on the sole condition that we do not grow weary or lose heart.
6:10	The Priority	As opportunity allows, do good to all — with first responsibility toward the household of faith, exactly as families care for their own.

⑤ APPLICATION

Closes the study · Personal & corporate

1. Sow Into Your Teachers

Scripture: *Galatians 6:6*

Drawn from Commentary I.

Paul treats financial support of those who teach the word as an ongoing partnership — sowing and reaping — not an optional courtesy. Whatever pressures argue against it, the responsibility remains the believer's.

Reflection: *Are you sharing "in all good things" with those who teach you the word, in a way that reflects an actual partnership rather than an afterthought?*

Practical Step: This week, take one concrete step — financial or otherwise — to support someone who faithfully teaches you the word.

2. Check What You're Sowing

Scripture: *Galatians 6:7-8*

Drawn from Commentary II.B.

Every use of your time and resources is seed — sown either to the flesh, which reaps only decay, or to the Spirit, which reaps a lasting reward. God is not mocked by which one you choose.

Reflection: *Looking honestly at your calendar and your bank statement this month, which field have you been sowing into more?*

Practical Step: Identify one specific expenditure of time or money you will redirect this week from flesh to Spirit.

3. Don't Lose Heart

Scripture: *Galatians 6:9*

*Drawn from Commentary III and FGR (Zane Hodges, *Grace in Eclipse: A Study on Eternal Rewards*).*

The harvest is certain, but it comes in "due season" — God's timing, not ours. The only thing that can forfeit the reward is quitting before the season turns.

Reflection: *Is there a specific work of good you have been tempted to abandon simply because you haven't yet seen fruit from it?*

Practical Step: Recommit to that work for one more defined season, and ask someone to check in with you on it.

4. Care for the Household First

Scripture: *Galatians 6:10*

Drawn from Commentary IV.B.

As we have opportunity, we do good to all — but Paul places a first responsibility on the household of faith, exactly as families take care of their own before anyone else asks.

Reflection: *Is there a need inside your own church family that you have overlooked while looking for ways to help outside it?*

Practical Step: Identify one person in your small group or church who has a tangible need, and meet it directly this week.

End of Study · Galatians 6:6-10